

This time around, Kartik Aaryan's Rooh Baba has to contend with the double trouble of Vidya Balan and Madhuri Dixit

and in your face. It should be sensible and not seem like buffoonery. The more serious you are, the better it is," he adds. Comedy, for Bazmee, is someone else's tragedy. But creating a fine balance of scares and laughs has its own set of challenges. "You create sudden jump scares and build the tension, or design the soundscape and build up dread with anticipation," he says.

Given how well the Maddock horror comedies *Munjya* and *Stree 2* have done at the box office this year, expectations are high that *BB3* will make it a hat-trick of superhits in the genre. Bazmee is cognisant of the current "mood" that has seen the genre thrive on the big screen, but he doesn't take the audience for granted. "I don't think people want to watch just one genre. Every Friday, people's mood changes," he says. It's why he's upped the stakes. Not just the cast (which includes Triptii Dimri) but the scale's bigger, too, thanks to a bigger budget from producer Bhushan Kumar. Bazmee elaborates on how with more special effects, grander sets and varied shot-taking, he has tried to make a film that's' "different, better and scarier than" *BB2*.

A lot's riding on *BB3* which will have to contend with *Singham Again*, another third instalment of a popular franchise, for eyeballs. On his part, Bazmee has delivered a threequel in a surprisingly quick turnaround time. He attributes it to the current entertainment landscape that has left the audience spoiled for choice. Says Bazmee, "Earlier, people's memory was strong, they'd wait 3-5 years as we made a film. But now the world's content is available at the tip of their fingers, thanks to OTT platforms."

It's through streaming where Priyadarshan-directed *Bhool Bhulaiyaa* (2007), which in itself was a remake of the classic Malayalam hit *Manichitrathazhu*, added to its fan base with Balan's scene-stealing portrayal of Manjulika, the possessed woman who terrifies as much as she delights. Balan's inclusion in Part 3 is likely to draw comparisons to the original as she reprises the role of Manjulika. A fan of her work himself, Bazmee is sure he's not going to disappoint the base. "We have tried to ensure it lives above the expectations," he says. "Her entry and what she does will impress audiences." ■

–Suhani Singh

(Italy). Releasing on Prime Video on November 7, and featuring Varun Dhawan and Samantha, the Indian *Citadel* is the most action-heavy of Raj & DK's creations so far.

For Raj & DK, the "unique opportunity" to work with creators in the US was both appealing and challenging. "There was a lot of apprehension...are we going to be good at this...will we have our own voice and identity?" asks Raj Nidimoru. "We made a show we want to make and the way we would make it," adds Krishna DK.

Citadel: Honey Bunny marks Dhawan's debut in long-format storytelling and also the first time he works with the filmmakers. Dhawan, a fan of Raj & DK's *99*, *Go Goa Gone* and *Stree*, which they wrote, says, "They were not coming to me, so I went to them. The show ticked every box–acting, action and great technicians." Playing stuntman Bunny who is secretly part of a spy network, Dhawan says that *Citadel* is mounted on an impressive scale. "It is an extremely cinematic show; it will probably look bigger than some of the movies in theatres," he notes.

There's at least one familiar face from Raj & DK's streaming universe in Samantha, who had a career-defining role in season two of *The Family Man* playing Raji, a Tamil rebel fighter. In *Citadel*, she plays Honey, a struggling actress who finds herself thrown into the espionage network. The show came at an arduous time for the actress who was diagnosed with myositis during filming. It left her so weak that she suggested the makers drop her from the show. "I am glad they didn't. I must have been a pain to work with, but I was never ever made to feel like one," says Samantha. She's grateful for her meaty part. "[Honey] is so layered, she isn't defined by anyone else, she is a survivor, a fighter and a mother. I can't believe I was able to pull this off, it's as much as I could ask from my body and mind." ■

–Suhani Singh

Featuring **Varun Dhawan and Samantha** (in pic), *Citadel: Honey Bunny* is the most action-heavy of Raj & DK creations